

Amendment No. 2 to HB0178

Behn
Signature of Sponsor

AMEND Senate Bill No. 471

House Bill No. 178*

by deleting the preamble and substituting instead:

WHEREAS, millennial women have come of age in an era marked by wage stagnation, skyrocketing student debt, unaffordable housing, and the rising costs of child care and health care, all of which make marriage and family formation increasingly out of reach; and

WHEREAS, over the past forty-five years, the decline in children living with married parents reflects not a rejection of family values, but the growing economic instability that delays or deters marriage and childbearing; and

WHEREAS, nearly a quarter of children today are raised outside of marriage, a statistic driven less by personal choice and more by structural barriers that make partnership and parenting financially precarious; and

WHEREAS, while children raised in stable, well-supported families tend to thrive, our focus must be on creating conditions where all families, regardless of marital status, have access to opportunity, security, and community support; and

WHEREAS, millennial women understand that marriage alone does not guarantee economic stability, especially in a landscape of wage inequality, rising medical costs, and inadequate family leave policies; and

WHEREAS, millennial women face a workforce that too often punishes caregiving and undervalues women's labor, making the prospect of balancing work, marriage, and parenting an overwhelming challenge; and

WHEREAS, millennials carry more student loan debt than any previous generation, delaying milestones like homeownership, marriage, and childbearing well into their thirties and beyond; and

WHEREAS, the high cost of child care, lack of affordable health care, and insufficient parental support policies have led many women to delay or forgo having children entirely; and

WHEREAS, despite narratives that tie personal success to marriage and childbearing, millennial women are redefining what it means to flourish, prioritizing financial independence, community connection, and personal fulfillment; and

WHEREAS, building a society where family formation is a real choice, not an economic gamble, requires addressing the root causes of inequality, investing in paid leave, child care, health care, and housing, and creating fair economic conditions for all; now, therefore,